CONTENT FOUNDRY

RESEARCH & PERSPECTIVES

BRANDED MICRO-DRAMAS

Give people a reason to come back.

The business case for stories worth following

Why invest. How to reach viewers. What to measure.



READER GUIDE

Inside this report

A practical guide for brand leaders who want to turn a message into a story people choose to follow.

01	The opportunity	3
02	Audience evidence	4
03	Brand examples	5
04	A commerce example	6
05	Production	7
06	Reach	8
07	Return on investment	9
08	Brand value and learning	10
09	The future	11
10	Work with Content Foundry	12
11	Sources	13

HOW TO READ THIS PAPER

Start with the business problem. Review the audience evidence and brand examples. Then use the distribution and ROI sections to shape a pilot your marketing and finance teams can evaluate.

Evidence, external campaigns, illustrative financial scenarios and strategic expectations are identified separately throughout.

01 | THE OPPORTUNITY

Your audience has a life. Let your brand become part of it.

People are looking for humour, inspiration, useful information and stories that feel close to their own lives. A brand can earn a place in that experience when it has something worth following.

Think of a family preparing for a celebration. A couple making a decision about their home. A young professional trying to belong. These situations can reveal a product's role more naturally than a list of features.

The question is simple: why would someone choose to watch the next episode?

A micro-drama is a short scripted series, usually made for mobile viewing. Its recurring characters and connected episodes create continuity. A branded micro-drama gives the product or proposition a meaningful role in that story.

What can this help your brand do?

Be understood: show a benefit in a situation people recognise.
Be remembered: connect the brand to a distinctive character or moment.
Build consideration: show why the proposition matters.
Encourage action: offer a relevant route to explore, enquire or buy.

These are goals to test. A series still needs good writing, clear brand linkage and a distribution plan. Entertaining viewers is valuable only if the intended audience also understands the brand's role.

For the client, the brief starts here

We want [audience] to understand [benefit] and take [action]. The story, production route and measurement plan follow from that sentence.

02 | AUDIENCE EVIDENCE

The viewing habit is already taking shape

India: Meta-Ormax study [1]	What a brand can learn
89% discover micro-dramas through social feeds.	The feed is an important discovery route. Budget for introduction and amplification.
Median consumption: 3.5 hours a week.	Viewers already make room for short episodic stories.
Viewing peaks between 8pm and midnight.	Test evening releases; also examine your own audience analytics.
Around 90% watch alone.	Think personal screen, clear captions and easily followed situations.

Scope: 2,000 personal interviews and 50 depth interviews, ages 18-44, across 14 Indian states; fieldwork November 2025-January 2026. These are micro-drama viewers, not a representative claim about every Indian consumer. [1]

What about the USA?

Deloitte's 2025 US research found that 56% of Gen Z and 43% of millennials surveyed considered social content more relevant than traditional TV shows and movies. [2] It is a reason to investigate the audience, not proof of a branded-series return.

A human lesson from the numbers

Make a story that can fit into a small pocket of someone's day. Open clearly, establish the situation quickly and reward the time they give you. Language and cultural context should feel local, whether the audience is in India or the USA.

03 | BRAND EXAMPLES

How brands are putting stories to work



Party of Two campaign key art: Meta / Instagram, September 2025. [3]

These examples show different ways to build brand meaning. They are external campaigns, not Content Foundry projects. Published outcomes vary; launches and viewing figures should not be mistaken for audited ROI.

Instagram | Party of Two | India, 2025 [3]

A seven-episode story about contrasting Gen Z flatmates supported Instagram's creative-expression campaign and ran on its own handles. The platform's proposition appeared through the characters' lives.
Lesson: give the brand idea a human setting.
Evidence: the launch documents the strategy and distribution; it does not publish sales or brand-lift results.

Maybelline | Maybe This Christmas | USA, 2025 [5]

Five episodes turned a holiday romance into a mystery around what people conceal. Instant Eraser Concealer had a deliberate role in the idea, with distribution on YouTube, TikTok and ReelShort.
Lesson: a product benefit can inspire the story's central theme.
Evidence: Maybelline's announcement explains the campaign; it does not report measured brand lift or ROI.

Kans | Mini-dramas plus livestream commerce | China [6]

Vogue Business reported a 102% year-on-year rise in Kans' Douyin GMV in 2024, alongside a strategy combining mini-dramas and livestreaming. The brand used stories to draw viewers towards product selling sessions.
Lesson: connect entertainment to a visible purchase journey.
Evidence: reported commerce growth from a combined strategy, not an isolated micro-drama effect or profit ROI.

The brand-building mechanisms are our interpretation of the published campaigns. Results depend on the audience, product, execution and commercial environment.

04 | A COMMERCE EXAMPLE

Crocs: give the product a role, then shorten the path to it

Crocs' **Deja Shoe** followed an aspiring stylist reliving a chaotic first day at a fashion company. The seven-episode TikTok series integrated product tagging, allowing viewers to shop featured footwear within the episodes. The launch also described localisation across seven additional TikTok Shop regions. [7]

How this supports brand building

Self-expression gave the footwear a relevant place in the character's journey. Product tags provided a direct route from interest to shopping. **Our interpretation:** the content and the commerce experience were designed together.

What is actually proven?

The partner announcement establishes the execution and shopping mechanism. It does not disclose conversion rates, incremental sales or profit ROI. Separately, the Wall Street Journal reported that Crocs' earlier *Charmed to Meet You* series attracted 7.8 million views in three weeks. [8] Those views belong to that earlier series, not *Deja Shoe*.

For an Indian brand, the equivalent next step might be a product page, a retail offer or a booking form. Use the commerce features available in the actual market; do not assume a US platform setup transfers unchanged.

05 | PRODUCTION

Human stories. Two ways to bring them to life.



Image: Content Foundry website portfolio. Illustrative production work, not evidence of micro-drama results.

Some stories need the chemistry of real actors. Others need an imaginative world or a visual treatment that is difficult to film. Content Foundry offers **both AI-based and shoot-based production**, with an in-house shoot studio and complete production infrastructure, backed by 30 years of advertising experience.

Approach	Choose it when...	Review carefully
Shoot-based	Performance, real product handling and everyday credibility carry the story.	Casting, product accuracy, continuity and usage rights.
AI-based	The concept needs stylised worlds or imaginative visual treatment.	Character consistency, product fidelity, motion and approvals.
Combined	Filmed products or performances benefit from selected generated visuals.	Visual integration, quality and scope.

AI is not automatically the cheaper choice for every brief. Test the look, consistency and revision requirements before finalising costs. The right choice is the one that makes the story convincing.

Agree scripts before production and final edits before release. Keep product claims accurate and sponsorship transparent; follow relevant platform disclosure requirements. [4]

06 | REACH

“But we only have 500 followers.”

That is a distribution question, and it deserves a clear answer. The series gives viewers something to follow. A discovery plan helps the intended audience find it.

Route	Practical role
Brand channels	Publish episodes and make the sequence easy to follow through pins, playlists or a series hub.
Paid media	Introduce selected trailers or episodes to relevant audiences. Test opening hooks before expanding spend.
Creators	Choose audience fit, content quality and credibility. Define fees, deliverables and usage rights.
Direct channels	Use permissioned email, WhatsApp or partner communities for interested audiences.
Languages	Adapt dialogue and cultural references for priority regions; review beyond literal translation.

A sensible release rhythm

Launch a trailer, then release episodes at a planned cadence. Use recaps and clear episode labels. Watch early retention, comments and response quality. Adapt supporting creatives as you learn.

Should the series have its own handle?

A brand handle keeps the journey simple. A separate series identity can suit a lasting story property, but it needs its own audience budget and moderation. Be transparent about sponsorship; a neutral-looking name is not a substitute for trust.

Making the series and getting it watched belong in the same plan.

07 | RETURN ON INVESTMENT

Make the numbers useful to your finance team

A series can create value through brand understanding, audience interest and commercial response. Financial ROI is narrower: it asks whether incremental contribution exceeds the campaign's total cost.

Campaign ROI = (incremental contribution - total campaign cost) / total campaign cost x 100.

Contribution means revenue less the agreed variable costs of fulfilling those sales, before the campaign cost. Count production, rights, localisation, creators, media and measurement. Keep the time horizon consistent.

Illustrative model - not a quote or forecast

Assume total cost of **INR 6 lakh** and contribution of **INR 3,000 per incremental customer**. That requires **200 additional customers to break even**. The same arithmetic applies in USD using the client's local costs and margins.

Scenario	Incremental customers	Contribution	Campaign ROI
Lower response	100	INR 3 lakh	-50%
Break-even	200	INR 6 lakh	0%
Higher response	300	INR 9 lakh	+50%

All figures are hypothetical. They are sensitivity scenarios, not estimated results for Content Foundry or any cited brand.

Connect the model to the sales funnel

If the assumed qualified-lead-to-customer rate is 10%, break-even requires 2,000 incremental qualified leads. At INR 6 lakh total cost, that is INR 300 per qualified lead. Change the margin or conversion assumption and the threshold changes.

Tracked enquiries are not automatically incremental. Use comparison or holdout testing where feasible. For longer sales cycles, agree a review window and update contribution as sales mature.

08 | BRAND VALUE AND LEARNING

Watch the story. Measure the brand.

A viewer can love a character and forget the sponsor. Another can remember the product but never need to buy it. Good reporting separates these outcomes.

Question	Evidence to collect
Did people stay?	Completion, watch time and available returning-viewer measures.
Did the brand register?	Recall, product understanding and proposition association through suitable research.
Did interest become action?	Tagged visits, qualified enquiries, bookings or offer responses.
Was it economical?	Cost per qualified response and incremental contribution over the agreed period.

Compare fairly

Record baseline content performance. Where possible, compare against business-as-usual creative with similar media spend, targeting and offers. Explain differences rather than declaring a win from an unequal comparison.

The value of reusable assets

A series may create episodes, trailers, stills and character edits. Count genuine savings only when these replace planned production costs. Do not convert every view or like into an invented rupee value, and do not add savings twice.

What to change when results disappoint

Low retention: revisit the opening and pacing. Strong viewing but weak brand recall: revisit integration. Relevant engagement but few enquiries: review the offer and landing page. Plenty of leads but few customers: examine lead quality and the sales process.

The pilot should tell you what to improve, not merely how many views to celebrate.

09 | THE FUTURE

From a campaign to a story people recognise

Deloitte predicted in November 2025 that global in-app micro-series revenue would rise from a forecast USD 3.8 billion in 2025 to USD 7.8 billion in 2026. [9] This is a forecast for content monetisation, not branded-content spending or a realised ROI benchmark.

Where we see the opportunity

Recurring characters: successful pilots may grow into recognisable brand story worlds rather than unrelated monthly films.
Regional relevance: language and cultural adaptation can open new audiences.
Commerce connections: suitable platforms can make the step from story to product simpler, as the Crocs example illustrates.
AI plus human judgement: selected production and localisation tasks may become more flexible, while writing, performance and quality remain decisive.
Audience-informed development: feedback can help teams refine hooks and future episodes.

These are Content Foundry's strategic expectations, not guaranteed forecasts. Competition for attention can increase, weak copies can crowd feeds and algorithms can make episode discovery inconsistent. Owning a clear series identity helps; it does not remove those constraints.

What should a brand do today?

Start with an audience and one proposition. Build a focused pilot. Test discovery, retention and brand linkage. Expand into new languages or seasons when the evidence supports it.

The early advantage is learning what your audience wants to follow.

10 | WORK WITH CONTENT FOUNDRY

Bring us the brand. We will find the human story.

You might be launching a product, explaining a service or trying to make your brand more relevant to a new audience. The first conversation should establish that need.

A practical starting point

A story session can explore three creative directions, each connecting an audience insight to your proposition and a useful next action. From there, we define the production approach and the pilot scope.

What the pilot should settle

Who is it for? Why will they watch? What role does the product play? Where will the series be discovered? What will it cost? What evidence would justify the next step?

Scope it clearly

Agree episode count and length, AI-based or shoot-based production, languages, trailer and cutdowns, revisions, approvals, usage rights, distribution and reporting. A 13-episode series is one possible structure; a smaller creative test can precede it.



Image: Content Foundry website portfolio. Supporting visual, not a quantified micro-drama case.

Content Foundry
AI-based and shoot-based production | In-house shoot studio
Complete production infrastructure | Backed by 30 years of advertising experience

contentfoundry.in
info@contentfoundry.in

11 | SOURCES

Evidence you can follow

[1] Meta-Ormax, India audience research, 18 March 2026
Read source

[2] Deloitte, 2025 Digital Media Trends, US survey
Read source

[3] Meta, Party of Two launch, September 2025
Read source

[4] YouTube, paid-promotion disclosure guidance
Read source

[5] Maybelline, Maybe This Christmas announcement, 24 November 2025
Read source

[6] Vogue Business, Chinese social-media brand strategy, 30 January 2025
Read source

[7] SuperOrdinary / Crocs, Deja Shoe announcement, 10 June 2026
Read source

[8] Wall Street Journal, brands and micro-dramas, 2026
Read source

[9] Deloitte, short-form serials forecast, 18 November 2025
Read source

Evidence and image notes

Research retains its original market and sample limits. External examples are not Content Foundry work. Reported GMV or views do not establish isolated causal impact or profit ROI. Forecasts remain forecasts; financial scenarios are hypothetical. Company capabilities and advertising-experience claims are supplied by Content Foundry.

Logo and portfolio visuals: Content Foundry website. Portfolio images illustrate production and storytelling, not measured micro-drama outcomes. Party of Two key art: Meta / Instagram launch announcement. All third-party brands retain their respective marks. Sources accessed 8 October 2026.